

State bill seeks to stub out vape pen trash

Legislation to ban disposable devices, a toxic waste plague, heads to Newsom.

By SUSANNE RUST

Vape pens and other disposable e-cigarettes soon could be illegal in California.

On Wednesday, the state Assembly approved Assembly Bill 762, which, if signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom, will make the battery-powered disposable devices illegal to manufacture, distribute or sell in the state. The bill passed the Senate on Tuesday.

“We are hopeful the Governor will recognize the threat these devices pose to our communities and that the costs of cleaning up the mess these devices leave are borne by ratepayers,” the bill’s sponsor, Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks), said in a news release.

The bill targets single-use, battery-embedded electronic cigarettes that contain tobacco products. Cannabis devices are exempt. To be legal under the new law, a vape device must be both refillable (or use replaceable pods) and have a rechargeable battery. Otherwise, they couldn’t be sold after Jan. 1, 2028.

Vapes have become a trash plague on streets and beaches and in parks where they leak toxic chemicals such as lead, lithium, cobalt, cadmium, chromium, copper, zinc and nickel as well as microplastics and battery acid.

According to consumer advocacy group CalPIRG, 500,000 disposable vapes are thrown away every day in the U.S. That’s almost 5.8 devices per second.

Vapes use a small lithium battery to heat liquids such as nicotine for users to inhale. Disposable vapes can be used only a few times before they become useless and have to be discarded.

The vaping industry says the technology saves lives and the cartridges are not nearly as bad a blight as cigarette butts.

Neither the Vapor Technology Assn., the largest industry trade group, nor the American Vapor Manufacturers, an industry group representing independent vapor manufacturers, could be reached for comment.

[See Vape ban, A8]



AMIR HOSSEIN KHORGOOEI Anadolu



WIN McNAMEE Getty Images

PRESIDENT TRUMP repeatedly has contradicted himself in an attempt to control the war narrative; top, a bridge in southern Iran hit by a U.S. airstrike.

‘We won.’ ‘Close to over.’ Trump’s Iran war timeline

Over six months, his comments have swung wildly

By Christopher Buchanan

WASHINGTON — For the last six months, President Trump has attempted to control the narrative of the Iran war.

As days, weeks and months passed, he repeatedly said that an agreement to end the conflict was close at hand and that Iran was already defeated. Between fraught negotiations, Trump has gone from conciliatory to antagonistic, characterizing Iran’s new leadership as more “rational” than their predecessors, only to later call them “sick individuals.”

There have even been times the commander in chief contradicted himself and his own Cabinet in the same week — and sometimes, the same day.

Friday marks the sixth month of the war launched by the U.S. and Israel. Among U.S. forces, there have been at least 18 killed and 758 wounded, according to Pentagon data. The Human Rights Activists News Agency puts the death toll in Iran at 3,636. In Lebanon, officials, say more than 4,300 have died. The Israeli military reported 72 deaths, and at least 50 civilians have died, according to news reports.

Here is a recap of notable comments Trump made in public remarks and on social media during half a year of war:

Feb. 28, 2026

What he said: “The United States military has undertaken a massive and ongoing operation to prevent this very wicked, radical dictatorship from threatening America and our core national security interests.”

In announcing the start of Operation Epic Fury from the White House, Trump called Iran the world’s No. 1 state sponsor of terror and recalled actions by Iran or its proxies, such as the hostage crisis of 1979 and the bombing of a Marine barracks in Lebanon in 1983 that left 241 dead.

The goals of the operation, Trump said, were to destroy Iran’s nuclear ambitions, its naval capabilities and missile industry and to ensure that Iranian proxies — including Hezbollah and Hamas — were thwarted. He implored Iranian citizens to rise up against the government.

What happened: That morning the U.S. and Israel conducted airstrikes on Iran, killing Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei as well as other key military and government figures. According to Iran’s Red Crescent, 24 of Iran’s 32 provinces were hit in the first day of bombings, with more than 200 deaths and 700 in-

[See Comments, A4]

A pledge to electrify I-5 freight corridor

Nations, states plan charging network for trucks to go from Baja to British Columbia.

By HAYLEY SMITH

It’s one of the busiest freight corridors in the United States, and it’s getting cleaner.

In the latest in the global effort to clean up heavy-duty freight, representatives from three countries gathered Wednesday at the Port of Long Beach to launch the British Columbia to Baja California Zero Emissions Vehicle corridor, or BC2BC, which, when complete, will make it possible for electric trucks to drive the length of the West Coast along Interstate 5.

The 1,381-mile corridor averages nearly 10,000 trucks each day — and sometimes as many as 35,000 — making it a backbone of North American freight movement

for huge volumes of agricultural products, lumber, consumer goods and other cargo. About 550 miles of the I-5 corridor pass through urban areas such as Los Angeles.

Officials from California, Oregon, Washington, British Columbia and Baja California have agreed to develop shared policies, investments and technical standards for the route. That includes set intervals between charging stations, similar siting of charging infrastructure and standards for installed chargers, among items outlined in a shared statement of principles.

Many chargers exist along the route already. Officials said the commitment will help fill in the gaps, and they aim to see Class 8 heavy-duty electric trucks driving the entire route as soon as 2030.

“Today marks the beginning of something extraordinary — a tri-national, five-state partnership to deploy

[See Trucks, A11]



JOSE FUSTE RAGA Gamma-Rapho

MESMERIZING

Japanese artist Yayoi Kusama, whose Infinity Mirror Rooms at the Broad continue to enchant Angelenos, has died at 97. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Democrats seek Olympics money

Lawmakers press the White House to speed up delivery of \$2 billion for transit for the Games. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny and hot. L.A. Basin: 95°/74. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Nuclear power plants on ships?

The Port of Long Beach partners with a startup to pursue small, mobile reactors. **BUSINESS, A10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 00200 5

Meta’s deal for child safety is just one step

Other countries have been cracking down on the use of social media among youths.

By QUEENIE WONG AND NILESH CHRISTOPHER

Over the last five years, efforts to make social networks Facebook and Instagram safer for young people have erupted across courts, classrooms and capitals.

Now Meta Platforms, the parent company of the world’s most popular social networks, faces another big moment of reckoning.

On Wednesday, Meta agreed to make changes to Facebook and Instagram to try to make the platforms safer for teens and those younger, along with paying up to \$17 billion over 10 years. The settlement would resolve a multistate lawsuit that alleged Meta designed and deployed addictive features that harmed young people and misled the public about the potential dangers.

Although politicians, advocacy groups and others applauded the settlement, the battle over child safety is far from over. Many are worried that social media continues to increase the risks of depression, anxiety, eating

disorders, bullying and other harms.

“This is an industrywide problem,” California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta said at a news conference Wednesday. “Meta is part of the industry, a major player in the industry, but there’s a bigger, bigger ecosystem.”

Shielding children from harm on social media is complex, as teens use the platforms to chat with family and friends as well as for entertainment.

Meanwhile, tech industry groups have sued to stop the enforcement of new child safety laws. Every day, the technology continues to evolve, introducing new ways for people to interact with online content. It is still unclear whether artificial intelligence will do more to help or hinder efforts to create a healthier relationship with technology.

“These are really difficult problems to solve, and no country, state, school, or family has figured it all out,” said Bethany Teachman, a professor of psychology at the University of Virginia.

Among other changes outlined in the settlement, Meta said it would have a default two-hour daily time limit that teens can turn off only with parental permission, mute notifications dur-

[See Meta, A11]

Legislation targets unethical lawyers

State lawmakers pass bills to limit shady outreach tactics and investor influence.

By REBECCA ELLIS

A bipartisan package of bills aimed at punishing unethical attorneys and hedge funds that have flourished within California’s legal industry is headed to Gov. Gavin Newsom’s desk.

The two bills would ramp up penalties for lawyers who scout for clients at hospitals, jails and accident sites, and bar lawyers from prioritizing the desires of private investors who fund lawsuits.

Assemblymember Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Los Angeles), one of the bill authors, said the legislation is intended to police the state’s bruised legal profession in response to “a wave of inappropriate attorney conduct” reported by The Times.

Times investigations last

year found some clients within L.A. County’s \$4-billion sex abuse settlement said they were paid to sue and, in some cases, to fabricate claims.

“When attorneys are exploiting vulnerable people, including paying folks to file fraudulent claims, they’re not just breaking the law, they really undermine the credibility of the legal system and every attorney,” Zbur said.

Both bills were sponsored by the Consumer Attorneys of California, a powerful trial lawyer trade group that says it wants to beef up punishment for misconduct.

“If we are going to demand that corporations, government, and powerful institutions be held accountable, we must be — and we are — willing to hold ourselves to that same standard,” Doug Saeltzer, head of the association, said in a statement.

California law already bans a practice known as

[See Lawyers, A8]

Patriot missile shortage risks Europe’s defense

Iran war has dwindled U.S. stockpile, leaving NATO vulnerable to an attack, officials say.

By EMMA BURROWS AND BEN FINLEY

WASHINGTON — The U.S. military is experiencing a “beyond critical” shortage of advanced missile interceptors in Europe largely driven by President Trump’s war with Iran, according to a U.S. defense official in Europe and a NATO official, raising concerns about vulnerabilities in alliance countries to a potential Russian attack.

The U.S. defense official said the most concerning shortfall involves Patriot missile interceptors, which can shoot down Russia’s high-speed ballistic missiles. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization official

confirmed the low inventories of Patriots among American and alliance forces in Europe. Both spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military matters.

In the event of a Russian ballistic missile assault on a military headquarters or power plant, for example, NATO could be in a similar position to Patriot-starved Ukraine and be forced “to take punch after punch in the mouth,” the U.S. defense official said.

In Europe, the American military “definitely” does not have enough Patriots to stop any possible sustained ballistic missile attack and would have “very limited” capability to defend against a single ballistic missile strike or a gray Russian missile that goes off course, the U.S. official said.

It illustrates the cascading fallout from Trump’s decision to launch a war

[See Patriot, A3]